The Scopes Trial: Darrow Examines Bryan

Clarence Darrow & William Jennings Bryan · July 20, 1925

Source: State of Tennessee v. Scopes (1925), trial transcript. Public domain. Continuous passage.

> In the Scopes “Monkey Trial,” defense attorney Clarence Darrow put prosecutor and Bible expert William Jennings Bryan on the stand, exposing tensions between literal readings of Scripture and modern science in a landmark clash of the 1920s culture wars.

Darrow. You claim that everything in the Bible should be literally interpreted?

[. . .]

Bryan. I believe everything in the Bible should be accepted as it is given there; some of the Bible is given illustratively. For instance: “Ye are the salt of the earth.” I would not insist that man was actually salt . . . but it is used in the sense of salt as saving God's people.

[. . .]

Darrow. Do you think the earth was made in six days? Bryan. Not six days of twenty-four hours. . . . Darrow. Do you think those were literal days? Bryan. My impression is they were periods, but I would not attempt to argue as against anybody who wanted to believe in literal days.